INDEPENDENT RESEARCH REPORT | 2026

# The True Cost of **a Missed Call**

How Service Businesses Lose $126,000 a Year —
Without Realising It

**62.2%**

of inbound calls to small businesses go unanswered

*Source: 411 Locals (2024), analysis of 85 businesses across 58 industries*

**85%**

of callers never call back

**62%**

immediately call a competitor

**$126K**

average annual revenue lost

THE PROBLEM

# The Scale of the Missed Call Crisis

For millions of service businesses in the United States, the phone is the primary revenue channel. A customer calls. If someone answers, the job gets booked. If no one answers, the customer moves on to the next result on Google — and that job is gone forever. What makes this crisis so damaging is how invisible it is. Most business owners never see the missed calls that cost them the most.

| 62.2% | 85% | 62% |
|---|---|---|
| of inbound calls go unanswered (411 Locals, 2024 — 85 businesses, 58 industries) | of callers who reach voicemail never call back (Aircall Research) | of missed callers immediately call a competitor (411 Locals, 2024) |

*Source: 411 Locals (2024). Study analyzed 85 businesses across 58 industries. Aircall Research. Lead Response Management Study, Dr. James Oldroyd, MIT/InsideSales.com.*

***"For every 10 people who try to call your business, 6 calls go unanswered — and 5 of those customers are gone permanently."***

## Why This Keeps Happening

The missed call crisis is structural, not behavioural. Business owners are not ignoring their phones. They are physically on job sites, driving between appointments, working in spaces where they cannot hear or respond. The phone rings, no one is available, and the caller — who had high purchase intent — moves to the next option. The problem intensifies in three specific scenarios:

| After Hours | Peak Season | During Ad Campaigns |
|---|---|---|
| 45% of high-intent calls arrive outside standard business hours. Most businesses have no coverage after 6pm or on weekends, which is exactly when motivated customers have time to call. Source: dialfyne.com (2026), compiled from ServiceTitan + BIA/Kelsey | HVAC, plumbing, and roofing businesses see 2-4x normal call volume during weather events and seasonal peaks. Staff cannot scale fast enough to answer the surge. Source: ACHR News seasonal contractor data, Contractor Magazine (2025) | Businesses running Google or Meta ads see 2-5x their normal call volume (Google Ads benchmarking data, 2022). Every missed call during a paid campaign is a double loss: the ad spend and the lead. Source: Google Local Services Ads benchmarking (2022) |

INDUSTRY BENCHMARKS

# Missed Call Rates & Revenue Risk by Industry

Missed call rates are not uniform across industries. They vary based on the nature of the work, staff availability, call volume patterns, and average deal value. The table below shows the three highest-impact service verticals, based on data from ServiceTitan, 411 Locals, Clio Legal Trends, and Invoca's call intelligence platform.

| INDUSTRY | MISS RATE | AVG CALL VALUE | ANN. REVENUE RISK | URGENCY |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Home Services (HVAC, Plumbing, Electrical)** | 40–70% | $275–$1,200 per call | $45K–$252K per year | CRITICAL |
| **Legal Services (Law Firms, Immigration, Personal Injury)** | 35–42% | $400–$2,500+ per matter | $80K–$300K+ per year | HIGH |
| **Real Estate (Agents, Brokers, Property Mgmt)** | 40–60% | $5K–$30K+ per commission | $200K+ per year | HIGH |

*Sources: ServiceTitan analysis of 50,000+ contractor phone lines (2024-2025). getaira.io (2026). Clio Legal Trends Report (2025). NAR Real Estate Survey. dialfyne.com Missed Call Statistics (2026). 411 Locals study of 85 businesses across 58 industries (2024).*

## A Closer Look: Three Industries

**Home Services**

The home services sector — HVAC, plumbing, electrical, roofing — misses more calls than almost any other industry. The reason is structural: technicians are physically on job sites with their hands full. A ServiceTitan analysis of over 50,000 contractor phone lines confirmed a 62% industry-wide missed call rate. During peak weather events (first summer heat wave, first winter cold snap), call volume spikes 200-400% above normal. The same technicians who are overwhelmed on jobs are the ones expected to answer those calls.

**Legal Services**

Law firms and legal practices miss 35-42% of inbound calls, but the per-call value makes each missed call extraordinarily expensive. The Clio Legal Trends Report (2025) found that 42% of callers who cannot reach a law firm on the first attempt contact a competitor immediately. For a personal injury or immigration practice, a single missed call can represent a $5,000-$50,000 matter that walks out the door. Unlike home services, legal calls are rarely repeat — most people seek legal help once, under stress, and hire whoever picks up first.

| Real Estate | Real estate agents miss approximately 40% of inbound calls, according to data from NAR and getaira.io (2026). The cost per missed call in real estate is the highest of any service industry — a missed buyer inquiry on a $400,000 home at a 3% commission represents $12,000 in potential lost income from a single unanswered ring. Property management companies exceed 60% missed call rates, as office staff are frequently occupied handling maintenance requests, tenant disputes, and inspections simultaneously. |
|---|---|

THE SPEED-TO-LEAD PROBLEM

# The First Responder Wins. Almost Every Time.

Answering the call is only half the problem. The other half is how quickly you answer it. Research from MIT and Harvard Business Review — conducted across more than 15,000 leads and 2,241 US companies — established findings that have only grown more relevant as consumer expectations accelerate.

| 21x | 78% | 47hrs |
|---|---|---|
| more likely to qualify a lead when responding within 5 minutes vs 30 minutes Source: MIT/InsideSales.com Lead Response Study | of customers buy from the first business that responds to their inquiry Source: Lead Response Management Study, Dr. James Oldroyd, MIT | average response time for US service businesses — nearly 2 full days Source: InsideSales.com (2025), 2,241 companies |

*Sources: Oldroyd, McElheran, and Elkington. 'The Short Life of Online Sales Leads.' Harvard Business Review, 2011. MIT/InsideSales.com Lead Response Management Study, Dr. James Oldroyd. Lead Connect (2024). InsideSales.com (2025) response time study across 2,241 US companies.*

***"After 5 minutes, the probability of qualifying a lead drops by 80%. After 30 minutes, you are 21 times less likely to reach them. After 24 hours, the lead is gone."***

## The Gap Between What Buyers Expect and What Businesses Deliver

Consumer expectations have fundamentally shifted. According to PwC (2024), 82% of consumers now expect an immediate response when they contact a business. They are not willing to leave a voicemail and wait for a return call tomorrow. If a competitor answers — or even responds by text within seconds — the original business is out of consideration before they ever know the call came in.

| < 5 min | 5–30 min | 30 min–1 hr | > 1 hour |
|---|---|---|---|
| Optimal window 21x more likely to qualify Lead is still warm | Acceptable Lead quality drops 80% Contact rate falling | Poor 10x less likely to qualify Competitor likely already called | Effectively lost 60x less likely to qualify (vs. 1-hour response) Lead gone |

*Source: Harvard Business Review (2011). MIT Lead Response Management Study. PwC Consumer Intelligence Series (2024). Blazeo Speed-to-Lead Benchmark Report (2026).*

REVENUE IMPACT

# What a Missed Call Actually Costs Your Business

The annual cost of missed calls for the average small service business is $126,000. This figure, derived from Invoca's 2022 Call Intelligence Report and validated by multiple subsequent studies, is calculated using conservative assumptions: 88 missed calls per month, at an average call value of $1,200, with a 10% conversion rate. For businesses in higher-value verticals or with higher call volumes, the true loss is substantially larger.

> ***"$126,000 per year. That is what the average service business loses to missed calls — not from slow service or poor reviews. Just from a phone that rings and no one answers."***

## The Compounding Effect

The revenue loss from missed calls is not linear — it compounds. When a customer cannot reach your business, they do not just go somewhere else for that one job. Research from NewVoiceMedia (2018) found that businesses lose an estimated $75 billion annually from poor customer service, with unreachable businesses being the leading driver. The long-term impact of a single missed call includes:

| | |
|---|---|
| **Lost job revenue** | The immediate loss — the job that went to a competitor |
| **Lost lifetime value** | A residential HVAC customer spends an average of $3,000-$8,000 over their lifetime with a single contractor. A missed first call means zero lifetime revenue from that household. |
| **Lost referral value** | Every satisfied customer refers an average of 2-3 others (Nielsen Word-of-Mouth Report). A missed call eliminates not just one customer but their entire referral network. |
| **Wasted marketing spend** | Businesses running paid ads that go unanswered are paying per click for leads they never convert. If 62% of calls go unanswered, up to 62% of ad spend generates zero return. |

*Sources: Invoca (2022) Call Intelligence Report. NewVoiceMedia (2018) Serial Switchers Report — $75 billion annual loss from poor service. Nielsen Word-of-Mouth Advertising Report. Google Ads benchmarking data (2022).*

THE SOLUTION

# How AI Voice Agents Are Closing the Gap

The research is unambiguous: service businesses need to answer every call, immediately, 24 hours a day, 7 days a week — including after hours, during peak seasons, and during ad campaigns. For a decade, the only solution was to hire more staff. That option is expensive, inconsistent, and unscalable. AI voice agents have changed the equation entirely.

An AI voice agent answers every inbound call in under 2 seconds — regardless of call volume, time of day, or staff availability. It qualifies the lead using natural conversation, captures the caller's name, need, and contact details, books appointments directly into the business calendar, and pushes every interaction to the CRM. No voicemail. No missed call. No lead lost to a competitor.

| | Human Receptionist | Voicemail | AI Voice Agent |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Available 24/7** | No | Yes (no response) | **Yes** |
| **Answers in < 2 sec** | No | No | **Yes** |
| **Qualifies the lead** | Yes | No | **Yes** |
| **Books appointments** | Yes | No | **Yes** |
| **Handles call spikes** | No | Yes (no quality) | **Yes** |
| **Cost per month** | $3,500+ | $0 (loses leads) | **$400–$800** |

## Introducing Skadi

Skadi is an AI voice agent built for service businesses in the United States and India. It answers every inbound call in under 2 seconds, qualifies the lead through natural conversation, books appointments directly into your calendar, and pushes every interaction to your CRM — 24 hours a day, 7 days a week, with no additional staff required.

**Live in 3 days. No tech team required. Starting from $667/month.**

READY TO STOP LOSING REVENUE?

# See Skadi Answer a Real Call.

Book a free 15-minute demo. We'll show you the agent live, answer every question, and calculate exactly how much revenue your business is losing to missed calls.

**Book Your Free Demo →**

theskadi.com | connect@theskadi.com

| 62.2% | 85% | 78% | $126K |
|---|---|---|---|
| of calls go unanswered | never call back | buy from first responder | lost per year on average |

Research compiled from: 411 Locals (2024) — study of 85 businesses across 58 industries | Harvard Business Review / MIT Lead Response Management Study (Dr. James Oldroyd) | ServiceTitan — analysis of 50,000+ contractor phone lines | Invoca (2022) Call Intelligence Report | Aircall Research | Clio Legal Trends Report (2025) | NAR Real Estate Survey | NewVoiceMedia (2018) | BIA/Kelsey | InsideSales.com (2025)